

RESEARCH ARTICLE

The Chickpea in Premodern China: A Perpetual Foreigner in the Central Lands

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Abstract

In this paper, I explore the millennium-long presence of the chickpea in premodern China by highlighting three key historical moments. The legume had its first rise to prominence as a cosmopolitan “Muslim Bean” in the Mongol Yuan (1271–1368) imperial diet. It then experienced a phase of obscurity, as the most renowned Chinese herbalist, Li Shizhen 李時珍 (1518–1593), conflated it with the pea. A disparate identity of the legume emerged around the same time, as the bean garnered attention from famine relief specialists, consequently transforming into a source of sustenance. The multiple lives of the chickpea were characterized with a common emphasis on its foreignness, drawing connections to various Eurasian cultures beyond China. The plant’s enduring presence, coupled with ongoing allusions to its alienness, makes it a perpetual foreigner in the broad expanse of the Chinese empire.

Keywords: chickpea; Muslim bean; Mongol yuan; Chinese medicine; famine relief

The chickpea, best known as the “Eagle’s Beak Bean” (*yingzui dou* 鷹嘴豆), has become popular in China today as part of a global trend that celebrates it as a healthy superfood. Far less recognized is the legume’s millennium-long history in premodern China.¹ Likely introduced as early as the 1000s, the chickpea was perceived in shifting ways, at times an exotic delicacy for elites, and at others a source of sustenance in times of need; yet it consistently retained an air of foreignness.

A methodological concern that needs foregrounding is a common issue widely encountered in the study of historical botany: the problem of nomenclature. The names and descriptions of the chickpea in Classical Chinese constitute what Leah Knight refers

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¹I use “China” as a geo-cultural concept referring to the territory in eastern Eurasia that hosted a variety of regimes, including the Sinitic Song (960–1276) and Ming (1368–1644) as well as the steppe empires Yuan (1271–1368) and Qing (1644–1911).

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to as a “tumultuous verbal display.”² Assuming that the chickpea existed in premodern China as a clear, intelligible material object, the naming of the object was already tenuous, as the plant was bestowed with multiple names by disparate observers. Furthermore, to name the chickpea was not a simple matter of matching a thing with a word. Some botanical namers might have experiential knowledge of the legume, while others might have never seen the plant. The naming process thus could be an empirical alignment of a thing and a label, a bookish task of fitting a name into a certain context, or a mixture of both. It requires historical detective work in each case to understand the nature of the naming process, and in many instances, modern scholars lack sufficient evidence to be certain.

It is thus more accurate to view the chickpea as a textual object rather than a material one. The history of the legume is best characterized as a medley of shifting textual identities, each emerging as a product of a specific historical context. The empirical knowledge of the legume held only marginal significance in the construction of a textual identity. To satisfy a historian’s undying interest in actual occurrences, I hone in on a selection of three textual identities of the chickpea, each backed by reasonable evidence of experiential knowledge of the legume.

At the core of each textual identity of the chickpea lay a name, accompanied by what I call a “textual nugget.” A textual nugget was a short description of the legume regarding its physiology, habitat, and/or medicinal attributes. The original authorship of these nuggets is often elusive, as they have been repeatedly reproduced and transplanted across writings and genres. So far as I can tell, each textual nugget concerning the chickpea has made multiple appearances across different texts, devoid of singular contents insulated to the intent of a specific author. The compilers who deployed these nuggets achieved their objectives by strategically pairing textual nuggets and names. Occasionally, they made slight alterations to the contents due to their own botanical judgements, while more often than not they left them unmolested in the original language. The textual nuggets thus possessed a degree of autonomy.

The three textual identities of the chickpea span the five centuries from the middle period of China to the end of the empire. The legume had its first moment of prominence as a cosmopolitan “Muslim Bean” in the 1300s. It then experienced a phase of obscurity as the most renowned Chinese herbalist, Li Shizhen 李時珍 (1518–1593), conflated it with the pea. A disparate identity of the legume emerged around the same time, as the bean garnered attention from famine relief specialists, consequently transforming into a source of sustenance for the impoverished.

The multiple lives of the chickpea were characterized with a common emphasis on its foreignness. It had been consistently named after Eurasian cultures on the margins of the Chinese empire, and during the period under study, it implied connections with various parts of the Islamic world. Though it carried a continual flair of foreignness, the legume remained tenaciously present, with some accounts noting its widespread availability. The plant’s enduring presence, coupled with ongoing allusions to its alienness, makes it a perpetual foreigner in the broad expanse known as the “Central Lands” (*Zhongguo* 中國).

Two aspects of this foreignness merit attention. For one, it was the product of a multi-centered Asia instead of a Sino-centric order, as the “Central Lands” passed under Mongol, Han, and Manchu rule, each connected with Muslim communities of their

²Leah Knight, *Of Books and Botany in Early Modern England: Sixteenth-Century Plants and Print Culture* (London: Routledge, 2009), 20.

own times. For another, the foreignness was a subdued exoticism, suggestive more of cultural flair than of blatant alterity. This tempered quality emerged, first, from processes of lexicalization, as references to foreign identity shifted from literal markers to coded meanings within cultural scripts, and second, from the Islamicate world's manifold locally shaped identities.

The constant bean

Before delving into history, it is crucial to first examine the chickpea through the lens of modern plant science. I base my search for the legume in historical sources on the physiological characterization of the modern chickpea plant. I state the method with awareness of potential pitfalls. Historians commonly rely on the physiology of modern plants to identify historical specimens, assuming that plant appearances remain consistent over time. As a methodological reflection, it is certainly worthwhile to ponder how the historical evolution of a species may impact the accuracy of our assessment.

Luckily in the case of the chickpea, modern plant science furnishes evidence to substantiate its own application. The biology of the modern-day chickpea remains largely consistent with its historical counterparts due to its highly limited genetic diversity. The chickpea (*Cicer arietinum* L.), the pulse legume we know today, has *C. reticulatum* as its immediate wild progenitor. The distribution of the wild progenitor has been extremely narrow, which leads to its low adaptive variation—a characteristic established as early as in the Neolithic period. The wild progenitor currently exists only in eighteen locations which gather in a narrow band (37.3–39.8°N, 38.3–43.6°E) in southeastern Turkey.³ In addition, the chickpea transformed from an autumn- to a spring-sown crop in the Early Bronze Age, which further reduced its genetic diversity. As a result, the plant already featured a low level of polymorphism long before modern breeding selection (see Figure 1).⁴

The physiological properties of the modern chickpea thus provide a reasonable framework for identifying its presence in premodern sources. A most critical characteristic for my inquiry is its habitat. The chickpea is a rainfed plant that remains poorly adapted to high

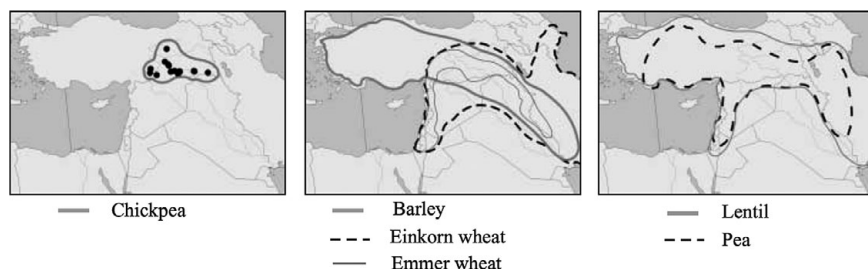


Figure 1. Comparison of Distributions of Wild Progenitor between Chickpea, Barley, Einkorn Wheat, Emmer Wheat, Lentil, and Pea. From Shahal Abbo, Jens Berger, and Neil Turner, “Evolution of Cultivated Chickpea: Four Bottlenecks Limit Diversity and Constrain Adaptation,” *Functional Plant Biology* 30 (2003), 1082.

³Shahal Abbo, Jens Berger, and Neil Turner, “Evolution of Cultivated Chickpea: Four Bottlenecks Limit Diversity and Constrain Adaptation,” *Functional Plant Biology* 30 (2003), 1081.

⁴Abbo et al., “Evolution of Cultivated Chickpea,” 1082.

rainfall, and a cool-season legume well suited for semi-arid and arid regions.⁵ The plant is thus not widely seen in southern China, where rainfall is high. In today's agrarian geography, the chickpea thrives best in the northwestern borderlands: modern Xinjiang, Gansu, Ningxia, and Qinghai.⁶ The appearance of the modern plant also furnishes critical references, particularly the relatively short pod yielding two to three beans, the fern-leaf structure, and the ram's head shape of the bean.⁷

The cosmopolitan Muslim bean

The first time the chickpea appeared in the spotlight concurred with the rise of the Mongol Yuan dynasty (1271–1368), when it was cherished as a culinary staple and a food of healthcare value under the name *Huihui dou* 回回豆 (Muslim bean).⁸ In Yuan vocabulary, *Huihui* was an inclusive term encompassing various peoples associated with the Islamic world. While it primarily referred to the Persians, it also included Arabs and Islamized Turks across the Eurasian steppes.⁹ Though appearing in commoners' recipes occasionally, the Muslim bean was primarily associated with the Mongol regime and signified the imperial ambition to integrate the Islamic and Sinitic cultures under the Turko-Mongol framework.¹⁰

The legume makes a most systematic presence in the *Yinshan zhengyao* 飲膳正要 (Essentials of the emperor's food and drink), a fourteenth-century compilation which included cooking recipes and dietary medicine. As evinced by the title, the text was intended for the Yuan emperor as a guidebook for culinary excellence and healthcare. Not only did the text cater to an elite palate, it also addressed a cosmopolitan elite specific to

⁵Eric J. B. von Wettberg et al., "Ecology and Genomics of an Important Crop Wild Relative as a Prelude to Agriculture Innovation," *Nature Communications* 9.649 (2018), 2, 8; Abbo et al., "Evolution of Cultivated Chickpea," 1084.

⁶For a summary of major chickpea habitats in modern China, see Yu Haitian 于海天 et al., "Yilang yingzuidou zhongzhi ziyuan nongyi xingzhuang yichuan duoyangxing fenxi ji zonghe pingjia" 伊朗鷹嘴豆種質資源農藝性狀遺傳多樣性分析及綜合評價, *Nanfang nongye xuebao* 南方農業學報 52.3 (2021), 770. Yunnan seems to be the only southern region with systematic cultivation of the chickpea, likely due to the large presence of the Hui people.

⁷The ram's head shape is specifically associated with the *kabuli* type, while the other type—the *desi*—is smaller and more irregular in shape. See L. H. Allen, "Chickpea," *Encyclopedia of Human Nutrition*, 3rd edition, ed. Benjamin Caballero (Cambridge, MA: Academic Press, 2013), 75.

⁸The earliest possible appearance of the chickpea was around the 1000s and known as the *Huihu dou* 回鶻豆 "Uyghur Bean." See Hong Hao 洪皓, *Songmo jiwen* 松漠紀聞, in *Quan Song biji* 全宋筆記 (Zhengzhou: Daxiang chubanshe, 2008), ser. 3, vol. 7, 133. Note that the majority of Uyghurs before the 1000s were followers of Manichaeism or Buddhism.

⁹For the definition of *Huihui* during the Mongol Yuan period, see Wang Dongping 王東平, "Yuan dai de Huihui, Huihui fa he Huihui hadisi" 元代的回回, 回回法和回回哈的司, *Minzu shi yanjiu* 民族史研究 1999.1, 271; Angela Schottenhammer, "Huihui Medicine and Medicinal Drugs in Yuan China," in *Eurasian Influences on Yuan China*, edited by Morris Rossabi (Singapore: Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, 2013), 89n1; Yang Zhijiu 楊志玖, *Yuandai huizu shigao* 元代回族史稿 (Zhonghua shuju, 2015), 78. The consensus among modern scholars is that *Huihui* mainly denoted the Persians with an emphasis on their Islamic association, hence my endorsement of its translation as "Muslim." A caveat is that the term was a generalized expression in its own times, applied flexibly by historical actors in ways that possibly extended beyond the Muslims; for example, it could encompass Christian Assyrians and at times became interchangeable with the much broader category *semu ren* 色目人 ("people of various kinds").

¹⁰For an example of a commoners' recipe featuring the chickpea that roughly dates to the 1300s, see *Jujia biyong shilei quanji, geng ji* 居家必用事類全集, 庚集 (ca. 1500s), 18a.

the Yuan world, where the Mongols ruled in assistance with various Eurasian peoples ranging from Jurchens in the east to Persians in the west. As Paul Buell and E. N. Anderson point out, the book presented a “new international cuisine” rooted in a Mongol core embellished with spices and techniques from China and Persia.¹¹ It articulated the “world conquering” ambition of the Mongols and materialized an imperial order sweeping across Eurasia.¹²

The author Hu Sihui 忽思慧 (d. 1330), a court dietitian, appeared well-suited for crafting this new international cuisine due to his multicultural background. Growing up in the Ningxia region, he spoke both Chinese and a Turkic language and was likely a descendent of the Hexi Uyghurs. He was evidently knowledgeable about the fusion of Sino-Turkic cultures in the northwestern borderlands and brought multicultural readiness to his service of the Mongol court.¹³

The chickpea’s identity in the *Yinshan zhengyao* comprised two parts: first, as a main ingredient in West Asia-influenced recipes, and, second, as a Chinese *materia medica*. This duality aligns with the structure of the text, which consists of three chapters, including a collection of West Asia-inspired recipes, an assemblage of drinks and liquid food, and a catalog of all *materia medica* used in its aforementioned recipes. The chickpea appears frequently in recipes across the opening chapter and reappears in the final section, standing out as the second most common foodstuff used throughout the book.¹⁴ The two parts were not perfectly coherent with each other; nevertheless, the discrepancies demonstrated Hu’s efforts to impart diverse cultural values to the legume.

In the opening chapter, the Muslim bean features prominently in twenty recipes, consistently as a thickening puree for soups/stews. The very first recipe, that of the “Mastic soup” (*Masidaji tang* 馬思答吉湯), is a good example of how the Muslim bean was used:

Mastic soup

It bolsters and boosts, warms the middle, and smooths the *qi*.

Mutton (one leg; cut up as pieces), tsaoko cardamoms (five), cinnamon (two *qian*), Muslim beans (half *sheng*; mashed and deskinced)

Boil all of the aforementioned ingredients into a soup. Strain broth. Add two *he* of cooked Muslim Beans, one *sheng* of aromatic non-glutinous rice, one *qian* of mastic. Add a little salt and adjust the taste. Add the cut-up meat and [garnish with] cilantro.¹⁵

馬思答吉湯

補益、溫中、順氣

羊肉一腳子卸成事件，草果五箇，官桂二錢，回回豆子半升搗碎去皮

¹¹Paul D. Buell and Eugene N. Anderson, *A Soup for the Qan*, 2nd rev. ed. (Leiden: Brill, 2010), 88.

¹²Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 88.

¹³Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 4.

¹⁴Shang Yanbin 尚衍斌, “*Yinshan zhengyao* de tedian ji shiliao jiazhi” 《飲膳正要》的特點及史料價值, in Shang Yanbing, *Yuan shi ji Xiyu shi congkao* 元史及西域史叢考 (Beijing: Zhongyang minzu daxue chubanshe, 2013), 233.

¹⁵In the Yuan, one *qian* was approximately 6.07 g, one *sheng* was 670 ml, and one *he* was 180 ml. See Wu Hui 吳慧, “Song Yuan de duliangheng” 宋元的度量衡, *Zhongguo shehui jingji shi yanjiu* 中國社會經濟史研究 1994.1, 16–23, at 7.

右件一同熬成湯，濾淨，下熟回回豆子二合，香粳米一升，馬思答吉一錢，鹽少許，調和勻。下事件肉、芫荽葉。¹⁶

The recipe incorporates the Muslim bean twice. First, the legume was boiled, skinned, and pulverized before being boiled with mutton, presumably melting into the texture of the soup. Then, additional cooked beans were added to the strained soup as a final touch. Overall, the legume was used to give body to the soup. The practice of boiling, skinning, and mashing Muslim beans was seen in all other relevant soup/stew recipes in the *Yinshan zhengyao*. Buell and Anderson identify the procedure with late medieval Middle Eastern techniques for cooking the chickpea, which affords circumstantial evidence confirming that the Muslim bean was indeed the chickpea.¹⁷

In the final chapter, Hu Sihui mentions the Muslim bean a second time, including it among over two hundred foodstuffs identified as *materia medica*. Each food appears with a description of physiological and healthcare properties articulated according to Sinitic medical theories. Hu divides the collection into five categories, the first being “rice and grains” (*migu* 米穀). The Muslim Bean appears in this category along with thirty other items:

The Muslim bean: sweet in sapidity and lacking in potency. Mainly used for treating “wasting thirst.” Do not eat it boiled with salt. It appears on the grounds of the Muslim territories, and the seedling resembles [that of] beans. Today it exists everywhere in the open fields.

回回豆子：味甘，無毒。主消渴。勿與鹽煮食之。出在回回地面，苗似豆，今田野中處處有之。¹⁸

This description once again supports the likelihood of the Muslim bean being the chickpea. Hu pinpoints the geographical origin of the legume as the “Muslim territories” (*Huihui dimian* 回回地面). Just like the term *Huihui*, the *Huihui dimian/tiandi* 田地 broadly denoted the Islamicate world, though historical actors employed it without precision, allowing its associations to shift with context. For example, in an edict in 1291, Kublai Khan (r. 1260–1294) employed the term to refer to both West Asia and East Africa connected by the Arabian Sea;¹⁹ and in a diplomatic document regarding taxing Muslim traders, Yuan officials invoked the term for the Il-Khanate (1260–1335).²⁰

Despite its ambiguity, the attribution of *Huihui dimian* makes the chickpea the strongest contender for the title of the Muslim bean. Locating the bean in the *Huihui* domain makes the Muslim bean part of an exotic minority in the *Yinshan zhengyao*. Despite the strong influence of the Islamicate world on the treatise, Hu explicitly identifies

¹⁶Hu Sihui, *Yinshan zhengyao*, *Sibu congkan* edition (Shanghai: Shangwu yinshuguan, 1935), 1.26b. Translation after Buell and Anderson with revisions, Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 270.

¹⁷Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 70, 106.

¹⁸Hu Sihui, *Yin shan zhengyao*, 3.3b.

¹⁹*Tongzhi tiaoge jiaozhu* 通制條格校注 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 2001), 27.636; and see Fu Zongwen’s 傅宗文 analysis, *Fu, Cangsang citong* 滄桑刺桐 (Xiamen: Xiamen daxue chubanshe, 2011), 205.

²⁰*Yuan dianzhang* 元典章 (Beijing: Zhonghua shuju, 2011), 22.906; and see Qiu Yihao’s 邱軼皓 analysis, Qiu, “Dade ernian (1298) Yili han guo qian shi Yuan chao kao: Faheluding Ahema Tibi de chushi jiqi beijing” 大德二年(1298)伊利汗國遣使元朝考：法合魯丁·阿合馬·惕必的出使及其背景, *Zhongyang yanjiuyuan lishi yuyan yanjiusuo jikan* 中央研究院歷史語言研究所集刊 87.1 (2016), 91.

only five foods as grown in the “Muslim territories,” the other four being mastic (*Masidaji*, *Mastajhi*), saffron (*Za’faran*, *Zanfulan* 咱夫蘭), almonds (*Badanren* 八簷仁), and pistā (*bisida* 必思答).²¹ All other foods had transliterated names, indicating a recent history of being imported from West Asia into China.²² While some other legumes such as the pea could also be used as a thickening agent, they lacked the prominent foreign connotation needed for inclusion in the *Huihui* food group.²³

The crux of this passage lies in Hu’s effort to incorporate the Muslim bean into the discourse of *materia medica*, a millennia-old tradition that defined Chinese medicine. He accomplished the goal by conveniently lifting a passage from a Tang pharmacopeia *Bencao shiyi* 本草拾遺 (Retrieved remnants of *materia medica*), despite the fact that the text was about a “foreign bean” (*hu douzi* 胡豆子).²⁴ Chen Cangqi 陳藏器 (681–757) writes:

The foreign bean is sweet in sapidity and does not have potency. It is mainly used for treating “wasting thirst.” Do not eat it boiled with salt. The seedling resembles [that of] beans and grows in open fields. It often appears among rice plants.

胡豆子，味甘無毒，主消渴，勿與鹽煮食之。苗似豆，生野田間，米中往往有之。²⁵

The first part of the statement, which Hu nearly quotes verbatim, contains what he needed the most: therapeutic properties couched in the language of Chinese medicine. The bean is described as having a sweet sapidity with no potency, a remedy for “wasting thirst.” The “sweetness” (*gan* 甘) belonged to the system of the Five Sapidities (*wu wei* 五味), a medical theory which organized the healing properties of foods/drugs according to sour, bitter, pungent, and salty, in addition to sweet.²⁶ A “sapidity” was not a description of an empirical flavor, but a prescription of medicinal functions of a food which likely—but not strictly—tasted sweet. With the modal sweetness, the Muslim bean would presumably help to alleviate acute movements of the *qi*.²⁷ By calling it “free of potency,” Hu identifies the bean as devoid of any salient therapeutic power; it would neither induce an immediate remission of an ailment nor cause any discernible harm.²⁸ But if someone suffers “wasting thirst,” that is, excessive thirst and frequent urination, consuming some Muslim beans would help alleviate the situation.²⁹ In addition, Hu advises against boiling the beans with salt, presumably only in the context of preparing the legume for a patient suffering from “wasting thirst.”

²¹ Here I emphasize the explicit identification of *Huihui*, while not excluding the possibility that Hu might recognize other foods as having Muslim origins without labeling them as such.

²² For the histories of these foods, see Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 535, 551.

²³ Additionally, Hu includes the pea/*wandou* 豌豆 in the same chapter, making it impossible to confuse the *wandou* and *Huihui dou* as the same legume.

²⁴ Hu generally referred to foreigners from the north and northwest.

²⁵ Chen Cangqi, *Bencao shiyi*, manuscript (ca. 1600s–1800s), 7a, National Diet Library Digital Collections, accessed August 20, 2024, <https://dl.ndl.go.jp/pid/2575592/1/8>.

²⁶ For a systematic introduction to the Five Sapidities in *materia medica*, see Chen Hao 陳昊, *Shenfen xushi yu zhishi biaoshu zhijian de yi zhe zhi yi* 身分敘事與知識表述之間的醫者之意 (Shanghai: Shanghai guji chubanshe, 2019), 333–34.

²⁷ *Huangdi neijing suwen jiaozhu* 黃帝內經素問校注 (Beijing: Renmin weisheng chubanshe, 1992), 7.315.

²⁸ For the definition of *du* as “potency,” see Yan Liu, *Healing with Poisons: Potent Medicines in Medieval China* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2021), 15.

²⁹ For the condition of wasting thirst, see Elisabeth Hsu, *Pulse Diagnosis in Early Chinese Medicine: The Telling Touch* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2010), 241.

Hu's effort to transform the Muslim bean into a *materia medica* appears congruent with his broader interest in adopting Chinese medical theories. The legume was part of an extensive collection of "rice and grains" occupying the top category of all foods, which was itself a salient convention in a Chinese pharmacopeia. Rice and grains were not the primary ingredients in the recipes documented in the *Yinshan zhengyao*, as they were not so central to the Turko-Mongol diet. According to Buell and Anderson, the elevation of rice and grains was due to the "Sinicized audience" Hu had in mind.³⁰ Along the same line, Hu duplicated much content in this category from Tang and Song medical texts, including the selection of species and their descriptions.

Against the backdrop of extensive replication, the Muslim bean stood out with a greater creative twist—it was the repackaging of old content under a new name. It was unclear whether Hu truly believed in the equivalence between the foreign bean and the Muslim bean. Practically, the lack of physiological description makes the textual nugget easy to appropriate, as it offers no details about the appearance of the foreign bean, allowing its properties to be easily transferred to a new specimen.

Nevertheless, potential inconsistencies existed between the foreign bean and Muslim bean, hence Hu's alteration of the language regarding the legume's habitat. He first adds the reference to the "Muslim territories," which was crucial to establishing the bean's unique geo-cultural associations. He further drops the segment on the legume's regular companionship with rice plants and substitutes a more generic statement that it "exists everywhere in the open fields." This adjustment partly aligns with modern plant science, which considers it unlikely for the chickpea to extensively co-exist with rice plants, as the latter primarily thrive in flooded paddies further south. But the new claim on its presence "everywhere" is also questionable, as it remains unclear whether Hu was suggesting a broad potential territory for cultivation across the "Muslim territories" or the Yuan empire spanning the north and south.

Could it be true that the chickpea was much more widely seen in China during the Yuan period? Some circumstantial evidence supporting this claim resides in the climate: during the Little Ice Age of the late Yuan, colder temperatures from the north to the south may have facilitated the habitat expansion of cool-season legumes like the chickpea.³¹ While it is challenging to find more specific proof, we should also not overlook what the statement literarily attempted to convey: it encouraged readers to believe in the wide availability of the chickpea, a point asserted to be true.

Taken together, the Muslim bean, presumably in significant quantities, brought a foreign flair into the Yuan imperial recipe for crafting a vibrant cosmopolitanism. By referencing *Huihui* in its name, the legume highlights the Muslim population in the empire, particularly the Persians, who were most active as officials, merchants, and technical experts under Yuan rule.³² From the emperor's point of view, it also symbolized

³⁰Buell and Anderson, *Soup for the Qan*, 125.

³¹Timothy Brook, *The Troubled Empire: China in the Yuan and Ming Dynasties* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2013), 53.

³²For the prominence of Persians under Yuan rule, see Bai Shouyi 白壽彝, *Huizu renwu zhi: Yuan dai 回族人物志：元代* (Yinchuan: Ningxia renmin chubanshe, 1985); Dror Weil, "The Fourteenth-Century Transformation in China's Reception of Arabo-Persian Astronomy," in *Knowledge in Translation: Global Patterns of Scientific Exchange, 1000–1800 CE*, edited by Patrick Manning and Abigail Owen (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh, 2018), 264–68; George Lane, "The Phoenix Mosque: Libaisi or the Temple of Ritual Salutations," in *The Phoenix Mosque and the Persians of Medieval Hangzhou*, edited by George Lane (Berkeley: Gingko Press, 2018), especially 35–36, 48.

the significant tie between the Il-Khanate—the western end of the Mongol sphere—and his own domain based in China.³³ Moreover, this Muslim-foreignness of the legume was not presented as a static feature; it was actively brought into an interaction with Sinitic culture. By morphing into a *materia medica*, the legume brought a healing power from the “Muslim territories” to address healthcare within the Chinese domain, effectively merging the eastern and western ends of the Mongol world into a mutually beneficial system. The chickpea transpired to be a mighty foreign presence—exotic, trans-cultural, and ubiquitous.

The bean which passed the foreignness

In this section, I discuss a historical moment when the chickpea became conflated with the pea and transferred its foreign allure to the everyday staple. The textual confusion emerges from the hands of Li Shizhen, the author of China’s foremost tome of pharmaceutical lore—the *Bencao gangmu* 本草綱目 (Classified *materia medica*). Li directly appropriated the Muslim bean and the erstwhile medicalization effort by Yuan authors, reinterpreting them under a new medicinal identity of the pea.

It all begins with Li’s desire to incorporate the pea as a new pharmaceutical item. Known as the *wandou* 豌豆, “the bean with curled [seedlings],” the pea was “a food of daily use” (*riyong zhi wu* 日用之物) and yet made no appearance in pharmacopeias before Li’s times.³⁴ Li addresses the omission by creating a medicinal identity for the legume through excerpts from existing medical writings. This approach was surely intriguing, as it directly contradicted his claim that there was no mention of the pea as a *materia medica*. To navigate this, Li selects certain legumes under other names and imputes their documented properties onto the pea—under the premise that all these other beans were but the pea with alternative names. The *wandou* is the “master name” (*zhengming* 正名), whereas all others are “alternative names” (*bieming* 別名).³⁵ In Li’s understanding, the master name *wandou* comes from a descriptive name of the plant in Classical Chinese, that “its seedlings are tender and curled” (*qi miao rouruo wanwan* 其苗柔弱宛宛), with *wan* 豌 being the phonetic loan of *wan* 宛.³⁶ Li assigns the Muslim bean to be an alternative name and incorporates most of its medicinal properties into his portrayal of the pea.

To “rescue” a legume with no existence in pharmacological literature, Li has to identify a “first” appearance of the pea which came under another name. He chooses the foreign bean recorded by Chen Cangqi—exactly the same choice as Hu Sihui’s—hence beginning the process of appropriating the Muslim bean. Chen’s description served his purpose well for its old provenance and ambiguity on physiology. Li drops the suffix *zi* and presents the term more formally as *hudou*, and then announces the equivalence between the *hudou* and *wandou*. He further asserts that the pea originated in the lands of “foreign barbarians” (*hu rong* 胡戎), justifying the invocation of foreignness by an overtly named foreign bean.³⁷

³³For the close connection between the Yuan and Il-Khanate, see George Lane, *Genghis Khan and Mongol Rule* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing, 2009), 83–100.

³⁴Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu* (Beijing: Huaxia chubanshe, 1998), 24.1022.

³⁵This is a system of nomenclature Li applies across the treatise. For a summary of research on this subject, see Li Shaolin 李紹林 and Li Dejun 李俊德, “*Bencao gangmu* ‘shi ming’ yanjiu zongshu” 《本草綱目》“釋名”研究綜述, *Shijie zhongxiyi jiehhe zazhi* 8.12 (2013), 1284–87.

³⁶Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1021.

³⁷Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1021.

Li then enumerates seven alternative designations, including the Muslim bean, all of which presumably referred to the pea in different times.

Li continues his appropriation of the Muslim bean in the section on “primary medicinal efficacies” (*zhuzhi* 主治), where he cites three references and adds one original statement.³⁸ The foremost reference again comes from Chen’s description of the foreign bean—now also the pharmaceutical characterization of the Muslim bean by Hu. It states that the legume was mainly for treating the condition of wasting thirst, and it should be consumed boiled bland.

The remaining two references are worth mentioning because they are also similarly arbitrary appropriations. The first comes from the entry on the *qingxia dou* 青小豆 (“little green bean”) in the *Qianjin fang* 千金方 (Prescriptions worth a thousand gold pieces), where the legume was described to facilitate urination and alleviate abdominal bloating.³⁹ At first sight it seems reasonable for Li to cite this information, as he claimed earlier that the little green bean was another alternative name of the pea. Intriguingly, however, he also cites the same language for his description of the *ludou* 綠豆, “the green bean.”⁴⁰ If we have to adjudicate which bean correctly merits the description, internal evidence from the *Bencao gangmu* points to the green bean: the rest of its profile demonstrates clear parallels with the line in question, a coherence which simply did not exist in the case of the pea. Similarly, the second medicinal description of the pea is a quotation from the *Riyong bencao* 日用本草 (Daily materia medica), one which originally describes the *candou* 蠶豆, “the silkworm bean” (the fava bean). The characterization shares no commonalities with the previous two, nor with Li’s own claim, which comes as the third.

Taken together, the medicinal profile of the pea is a disjointed composition based on appropriation of other legumes. The majority of its healing efficacies come from earlier writings on legumes with different names, starting with the Muslim bean. If this can be explained away with Li’s theory of master and alternative names, the disparity among therapeutic effects demonstrates an even less defensible inconsistency in medical argument. The efficacy portfolio of the pea, indeed, is a patchwork resulting from bookish efforts to assemble a new narrative. It remains a question whether Li had truly encountered a chickpea plant before appropriating the Muslim bean, as he could have done the textual work without direct experience.

Despite the uncertainty surrounding Li’s firsthand understanding of the legume, he demonstrates a keen interest in the textual record of the Muslim Bean, also found in his discussion of general health benefits. In the section “Explications” (*faming* 發明), Li centers the Yuan narrative and cites Hu’s use of the bean in the *Yinshan zhengyao* recipes:

In Yuan drink and food practices, whenever this bean is used, it is pulverized and skinned, consumed together with mutton. It is said to boost the center and facilitate the *qi*.

元時飲膳，每用此豆搗去皮，同羊肉治食，云補中益氣。⁴¹

³⁸For all quotations in this and the next paragraph, see Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1022.

³⁹Sun Simiao 孫思邈 (581–682), *Qianjin fang* (Beijing: Zhongguo zhongyiyao chubanshe, 1998), 26.434.

⁴⁰Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1019.

⁴¹Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1022.

To Li, the efficacies of “boosting the center and facilitating the *qi*” align with the connection between the pea and the Earth Phase:

The pea belongs to the Earth, and it is thus often used for treating diseases of the spleen and the stomach.

豌豆屬土，故其所主病多系脾胃。⁴²

The pea facilitates the spleen and the stomach with a force emerging from the Phase of the Earth, which justifies its frequent use in health-boosting recipes, such as the mutton stews in the *Yinshan zhengyao*. This reasoning reflects the attention Li devotes to the Yuan treatise. He incorporates both aspects of the Muslim bean—not only the Sinitic side manifest in the *materia medica* discourse but also the Eurasian facet, where the bean features in West Asian culinary recipes. The connection was by itself not so accurate, as in the Yuan cookbook, the mutton soup, not the beans alone, contribute to “boosting the center and facilitating the *qi*.” The imprecision, nevertheless, emerges outright from Li’s eagerness to integrate as much Yuan material as possible.

At this point, it might appear that Li has successfully subjugated the Muslim bean to the reign of the pea. Most conspicuously, the legume has lost its foreign aura by dropping the reference to the Muslims and come under a master name rooted in literary Classical Chinese. But Li was not motivated by xenophobia towards foreign connections; on the contrary, he transposed the Eurasian connection into the identity of the pea and amplified it.

Li’s intention to highlight the foreignness of the pea becomes evident in the opening line of his physiological description of the legume:

The pea was a specimen originating in the Western foreign lands, and it appears abundantly in the north today.

豌豆種出西胡，今北土甚多。⁴³

While Li is correct that the legume originated in regions to the west of China, its foreign provenance had receded into obscurity in quotidian contexts at least a millennium before his time.⁴⁴ A brief look into the history of the pea may help clarify this. Prior to Li’s rebranding project, the pea was a staple food and everyday source of sustenance. It was food for everyone, particularly for those in need. Judging by extant evidence, the term *wandou* first appeared in writings from the Six Dynasties (220–589), including the famous agricultural treatise *Qimin yaoshu* 齊民要術 (Techniques essential for the

⁴²Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1022.

⁴³Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1022. Shang Yanbin 尚衍斌 considers this paragraph a quotation from the *Shiwu bencao* 食物本草, a text he attributes to the Yuan dynasty. Shang, “‘Huihui douzi’ yu ‘Huihui cong’ de sai kao shi” “‘回回豆子’與‘回回蔥’的再考釋”, *Zhongguo Hui shang wenhua* 中國回商文化 2009.2, 172. A number of other scholars, however, date the treatise to the sixteenth century, which I endorse. See, for example, Zhang Zhibin 張志斌, “Ming *Shiwu bencao* zuozhe ji chengshu kao” 明《食物本草》作者及成書考, *Zhongyi zazhi* 中醫雜誌 2012.53, 1588–91. The statement thus should be Li’s original.

⁴⁴Some scholars believe that the pea came to China from the eastern Mediterranean. See Shang Yanbin, “Hu Sihui *Yinshan zhengyao* buming mingwu kao” 忽思慧《飲膳正要》不明名物考, *Zhejiang shida xuebao* 浙江實達學寶 26.1 (2001), 45.

subsistence of common people) and a number of Buddhist texts. Behind its textual debut was a legume already naturalized into Chinese foodways. The term *wandou* consistently referred to a legume for daily consumption, and the bean was so commonplace in everyday life that it became a reference object for size comparison.⁴⁵ “Like the pea” (*ru wandou* 如豌豆) served as a familiar metaphor for a tiny quantity, a function that could only be fulfilled by a ubiquitously available object.⁴⁶

The wide presence of the pea had to do with its hardy and prolific nature, a merit well recognized in agricultural writings from the middle period through Li’s time. In *Nongsang jiyao* 農桑輯要 (Essentials of agriculture and sericulture), the compilation encompassing numerous earlier farming treatises, the author highly praises the pea for its early harvest time, abundance, low-maintenance, and extended durability.⁴⁷ The Song author Dong Wei 董煟 (fl. ca. early 1200s) in his *Jiuhuang huomin shu* 救荒活民書 (Book for relieving famines and saving the people) mentions a case in which the legume helped avert a famine because of its strong resistance to locusts.⁴⁸ As Li Shizhen nicely summarizes himself, the pea was “the foremost among all kinds of grains” for its extraordinary capacity to feed a large population cost-efficiently.⁴⁹

Therefore, while Li’s statement on the pea’s foreign origin may be accurate, it would nevertheless astonish some of his contemporaries, who consumed the legume daily and took its familiarity for granted. Li might have various reasons for attributing novelty to something so commonplace, but one practical concern could be leveraging the pea into medical discourse. To be sure, being exotic was not a requirement for a species to claim pharmaceutical value; in fact, numerous quotidian foods including rice and soybeans had obtained *materia medica* status long before. What was curious about the pea, as Li stated himself, was its exclusion from this class of therapeutic foods. Highlighting a possible foreign origin was an expedient way to account for this long-standing omission and to expedite its inclusion. Returning to the chickpea, the Muslim bean imparted a Eurasian quality to the pea, despite losing its distinctly foreign name. Its foreignness gained renewed significance once it became integrated into a staple deeply embedded in the everyday cuisine of the empire.

Given his historical status as the premier herbalist, Li’s conflation of the chickpea with the pea had an enduring influence for the next three centuries. Numerous texts including pharmacopeias, herbals, general encyclopedias, and gazetteers, simply quote the equivalence of the two legumes.⁵⁰ Determining whether each author had empirical knowledge of both plants requires a case-by-case investigation. However, it is likely that many authors, particularly those in the south, simply recognized the pea by its various names without even realizing the existence of the chickpea. This to a certain extent caused the “extinction” of the chickpea in the textual world.

⁴⁵For example, see Buddhahadra (359–429) and Faxian 法顯 (338–423), *Mohe Sengqi Lü* 摩訶僧祇律 (*Mahāsāṃghikas Vinaya*), T. 22, no. 1425, 3.244.

⁴⁶Buddhabhadra and Faxian, *Mohe Sengqi Lü*, 18.369.

⁴⁷*Nongsang jiyao*, *Siku quanshu* edition (Taipei: Taiwan shangwu yinshuguan, 1983–86), 2.13b–14a.

⁴⁸Dong Wei, *Jiu huang huo min shu*, *Siku quanshu* edition (Taipei: Taiwan shangwu yinshuguan, 1983–86), 2.25b–26a.

⁴⁹Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 24.1022.

⁵⁰For pharmacopeias and encyclopedias, see Zhao Nanxing 趙南星 (1550–1628), *Shang yi bencao* 上醫本草 (Beijing: Zhongyi guji chubanshe, 1996), 1.34a–b; Wang Hao 汪灝 (*jinshi* 1685), *Guang qun fang pu* 廣群芳譜, *Neifu* edition (1701), 10.11a. For gazetteers in the south, see *Xinjin xian zhi* 新津縣志 (1839), 29.1a; *Anyue xian zhi* 安岳縣志 (1836), 15.1a; and *Xiaogan xian zhi* 孝感縣志 (1883), 5.31b.

Local writings from some northwestern provinces provide an intriguing continuation of Li's narrative. Judging by their physiological descriptions, many authors clearly recognize the differences between the two legumes, which affirms that the cultivation of the chickpea today in these regions traces back at least to the Ming. Based on a robust empirical understanding, many of these authors list the pea and the Muslim Bean as distinctive foods.⁵¹ Others reproduce Li's language of equivalence, albeit not to the effect of erasing the chickpea but of emphasizing the pea's foreignness. The *Chongxiu Zhenyuan xian zhi* 重修鎮原縣志 (Revised gazetteer of Zhenyuan, 1936), for example, is a gazetteer of a county in modern Gansu, the heartland of chickpea cultivation. The text introduces the *wandou* as follows:

One variety [of the pea] has the shape of a round vault, resembling the Muslim hat. Its common name is the Muslim bean, or the peach bean. According to the *Bencao gangmu*, the pea is also known as the foreign bean, the bean of the mountain barbarians, or the Uyghur bean.

一種形銳圓似回回帽者，俗名回回豆，亦名桃兒豆。《本草綱目》豌豆一名胡豆，一名戎菽，一名回鶻豆。⁵²

While the latter half of this statement is a reiteration of Li's argument, the first half is clearly a description of the chickpea. The new alternative name peach bean furnishes telling evidence. A round peach with a pronounced suture looks more similar to the ram's head shape of the chickpea than a smooth pea. The term "peach bean" was part of a trend in descriptive naming that started no later than the Ming, when northwesterners named the chickpea based on its resemblance with other familiar objects, such as the "chicken's head bean" (*jitou dou* 雞頭豆) and "eagle's beak bean."⁵³ Whether referring to a peach, a chicken's head, or an eagle's beak, all described a spherical shape with a ridge, typical of the chickpea.

The overtly ethnizing tone of the statement is also worth consideration. The comparison to the "Muslim hat" (possibly the *doppa*) ascribes a form of ownership of the legume to the modern Uyghurs. The text then further corroborates this ethnic ascription by citing selected historical names, all of which reference a Eurasian connection, whether "mountain barbarians" (a designation of ancient Xiongnu) or the *Huihu* (pre-Islamized medieval Uyghurs).

Given the detailed descriptions of unique physiology and ethno-cultural associations, the claim of equivalence between the chickpea and the pea no longer had the power to overshadow the former legume. Instead, the pea was now ascribed with a history consistently embedded in Eurasian steppe cultures from antiquity to the present. Similar to Li's account but extending beyond it, its merging with the chickpea caused the pea's identity to shift from quotidian banality to marginalized foreignness.

⁵¹For examples, see *Lintao fu zhi* 臨洮府志 (1605), 8.5a; *Longde xian zhi* 隆德縣志 (1663), 1.11b; and *Huai'an xian zhi* 淮安縣志 (1852), 24.1a.

⁵²*Chongxiu Zhenyuan xian zhi* (1936), 2.10b.

⁵³For example, the term *yingzui dou* appears in gazetteers of Ningxia during the Hongzhi reign (1488–1505), and *jitou dou* repeatedly appears in gazetteers of Longde—a county in Ningxia—from the Jiajing reign (1522–1566) onward. See Zhang Weishen 張維慎, "Ningxia nongmu ye fazhan yu huanjing bianqian yanjiu" 寧夏農牧業發展與環境變遷研究 (PhD diss., Shaanxi Normal University, 2002), 192–93.

The Bean for the Poor

Whereas Li Shizhen's appropriation diminished the chickpea to a certain extent, the legume received a new identity from his contemporaries who wrote with food insecurity on the mind.⁵⁴ This is perhaps the historical moment when we can recognize the legume with the greatest certainty, as its appearance is documented in specific language and aided with visualizations. The famine-relief treatises present the bean as an edible plant in times of need, providing thus far the most reliable guidance for a forager to find it in the wild. The legume resumes its old name—the *Huihui dou*—and yet it shares little in common with the previous Muslim bean in textual presentation. It rejects medicalization and appears with minimal conceptual embellishment. The legume's foreignness takes on a new meaning in these texts: it moves away from exoticism toward interactive engagement with specific Eurasian communities, as it is now presented as a famine staple, identified by names reflecting Turko-Iranian phonetics.

The new Muslim bean once again consists of a recurring textual nugget describing its characteristics, one which first appears in the *Jiuhuang bencao* 救荒本草 (Plants for famine relief). The text was released in 1406 under the name of a prince Zhu Su 朱橚 (1361–1425).⁵⁵ According to Bian Tong 卞同 (fl. ca. 1400s), author of the first preface, the treatise emerged from Prince Zhu's intention to document wild edibles, a subject so important for famine relief and yet regrettably neglected by existing pharmacopeias.⁵⁶ "Edibility" (*keshi* 可食) stands out as the most pivotal criterion of classification throughout the *Jiuhuang bencao*.⁵⁷ The treatise is first divided into food groups such as herbs, rice and grains, and fruits, with each category being further organized according to the edible parts, including "edible leaves" (*ye keshi* 葉可食), "edible flowers" (*hua keshi* 花可食), and "edible seeds" (*shi keshi* 實可食). The Muslim bean is a member of the rice and grains category with "edible seeds."

According to the preface, the focus on edibility led the prince to rigorously pursue firsthand knowledge. He created a garden where he could observe and document plants in a controlled environment. Zhu consulted seasoned cultivators, acquired over four hundred varieties of seedlings, and oversaw their planting under his personal supervision. When they reached full growth, he commissioned painters to illustrate them.⁵⁸ As such, Zhu documented plants with both words and images, ensuring a two-pronged reliability.

Against the overarching focus on reliability, Zhu's description of the Muslim bean is as follows:

The Muslim bean is also known as the *nahe*-bean. It grows in open fields. The stem is green, and the leaves resemble those of the *jili* (prickly weed). The leaves also look like those of a new, tender *zaojia* (soap pod) for the tiny serrated edges. The plant produces a light purple flower with five petals, which resembles that of the *jili*. The

⁵⁴The first famine treatise I will discuss, the *Jiuhuang bencao* precedes the *Bencao gangmu*, and Li cites it in the bibliography. Li Shizhen, *Bencao gangmu*, 11.

⁵⁵For the pioneering study of this text, see Joseph Needham, Lu Gwei-Djen, and Huang Hsing-Tsung, *Science and Civilisation in China, Volume 6: Biology and Biological Technology, Part I: Botany* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1986), 331–48; for a recent in-depth study, see Chen Huang, "Mapping the Knowledge of Famine Foods in Late Imperial China" (PhD diss., City University of Hong Kong, 2023).

⁵⁶Zhu Su, *Jiuhuang bencao jiaoshi yu yanjiu* 救荒本草校釋與研究 (Beijing: Zhongyi guji chubanshe, 2007), "Preface," 10.

⁵⁷For an explication of this concept, see Huang, "Mapping the Knowledge," 20–56.

⁵⁸Zhu Su, *Jiuhuang bencao*, "Preface," 9.

pod it grows has the shape of an apricot kernel, and it bears beans similar with the seed of *qianniu* (ox-leading). [The bean] is slightly big and tastes sweet.

回回豆, 又名那合豆, 生田野中, 莖青, 葉似蒺藜葉, 又似初生嫩皂莢, 而有細鋸齒, 開五瓣淡紫花, 如蒺藜花樣, 結角如杏人樣, 有豆如牽牛子, 微大味甜。⁵⁹

The author then presents how the bean may be useful for famine relief, which could be as simple as “plucking the beans and boiling them to eat” (*cai dou zhu shi* 採豆煮食).⁶⁰

Multiple details in the description suggest that this Muslim bean is the chickpea and that the author had experiential knowledge of it. In contrast to the Yuan account, the textual nugget features an elaborate physiological description, including details on the stem, leaf, flower, pod, and seed, all critical components of the plant. More convincingly, it is described through an array of comparisons with various other species, including the *jili*, *zaojia*, apricot kernel, and *qianniu*, which fit well with the appearance of the chickpea plant. The account was likely written by someone with rich, firsthand knowledge of not only the chickpea, but also botany in general.

The *Jiuhuang bencao* also leaves no room for nomenclature ambiguity. It features a detailed taxonomy of legumes including the wild pea (*ye wandou* 野豌豆), the fava bean, and a different “foreign bean,” each with a distinguished appearance. The juxtaposition eliminates the possibility of conflating the chickpea with the usual suspects and preempts the confusion caused by Li Shizhen.

For the illustration, which was presumably made by court painter-craftsmen, see Figure 2.

The image conveys that the leaves were small, abundant, and somewhat clustered together, which is congruent with the comparison to the *jili* leaves in the verbal description. It does not, however, include the visualization of the flower, the pod, nor the bean. It remains unclear to me whether it would serve as sufficient visual reference for one to identify the plant.⁶¹

The visual component witnessed improvement, nevertheless, as the textual nugget rolled forward into subsequent treatises of a similar nature. The same description of the Muslim bean appeared in *Yecai bolu* 野菜博錄 (Comprehensive documentation of wild vegetables) published by Bao Shan 鮑山 (fl. ca. 1620s).⁶² While Bao quoted Zhu verbatim in the textual part, he presented a new illustration with more compelling evidence to match the Muslim bean with the chickpea (see Figure 3).

The most important clue lies in the visualization of the pod, which appears relatively short with a yield of two or three beans. This fits with the comparison of the pod to an apricot kernel, which should be noticeably different from a longer pod like that of the pea; the two-to-three yield of beans in each pod also aligns with the description of the bean being “slightly big.”

⁵⁹Zhu Su, *Jiuhuang bencao*, 2.285–286.

⁶⁰Zhu Su, *Jiuhuang bencao*, 2.285.

⁶¹Despite uncertainties about this case, both contemporaries and modern scholars have praised the illustrations for their efficacy in guiding identification, see Georges Métaillé, *Science and Civilisation in China, Volume 6: Biology and Biological Technology, Part IV: Traditional Botany and Ethnobotanical Approach*, trans. Janet Lloyd (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2015), 163–67, and Huang, “Mapping the Knowledge,” 79–84.

⁶²Bao Shan, *Yecai bolu*, *Sibu congkan* edition (Shanghai: Shangwu yinshuguan, 1935).



Figure 2. Illustration of the Muslim Bean, Zhu Su, *Jiu Huang bencao* (1555), 2. 54b. Library of Congress, www.loc.gov/item/2012402246/. This is the same illustration used in all extant versions, including the 2007 modern edition.



Figure 3. Illustration of the Muslim Bean, Bao Shan, *Yecai bolu*, 2.67a.

The Muslim bean in famine-relief manuals demonstrates a clear break from its counterpart in pharmacopeias.⁶³ The legume has morphed from an exotic healthcare dietary product into a basic foodstuff for sustenance. In this new textual description, the *Huihui dou* appears as a bare bean stripped of medicinal attributes. The mention of a “sweet flavor” characterizes the bean’s natural sugar content, as it immediately follows its size description. The context makes it evident that its sweet flavor is distinct from the medically loaded “sweet sapidity.” The intended accessibility of the Muslim bean is also evidenced by the style of the presentation, particularly the generous use of comparative references. All of the plants compared to the Muslim bean are fairly common specimens, indicating a good-faith effort to provide guidance for foragers in need.

The text also suggests that the new Muslim bean occupied a broader habitat, which would further add to its accessibility. If the legume was truthfully included in Zhu’s experiment, the plant should grow fine in Henan—a junction linking northern and southern China—where the prince was enfeoffed. If the statement on its growth in open fields is a first-hand observation, the chickpea plant should find Henan not only an acceptable habitat but a conducive environment for thriving in the wild.

Yet the plain, accessible staple still carried a foreign flavor, notably with its transliterated name *nahe dou* 那合豆. Angela Schottenhammer identifies *nahe* as *nakhod*, the Persian name of the chickpea, which appears in the *Huihui yaofang* 回回藥方 (Muslim formulas), a collection of translated Arabo-Persian medical texts in Ming China.⁶⁴ This is an ideal example of matching contemporaneous terms. The Persian word had by then developed into a number of variants, such as *noqut* نوقوط in modern Uyghur, *nohut* in modern Turkish, *noxud* in Azerbaijani, *năut* in Romanian, and *nut* нут in Ukrainian.⁶⁵ The Chinese *nahe* belongs to this relay of transliterations across Eurasian languages.

While it is generally difficult to ascertain how a transliterated name was initially adopted, a variant of *nahe* sheds some light on a specific context in the eighteenth century. In the *Qinding Huangyu Xiyu tuzhi* 欽定皇輿西域圖志 (Imperially commissioned illustrated records on the western regions in the imperial domain), there is a legume identified as *nahu* 納呼 and a local product of the “lands of the Uyghur tribes” (*Huibu tudi* 回部土地).⁶⁶ This plant is probably the chickpea.

Presumably, the adoption of the name *nahu* is the result of documenting the indigenous way of referring to the legume during an experiential encounter. The *Huangyu Xiyu tuzhi* was a gazetteer of Xinjiang—the “Western Regions”—and a celebration of the recent annexation of the area into Qing territory. Before the Qing conquest, the Oirat Mongol regime Zunghar Khanate (1634–1758) ruled Xinjiang and its Uyghur inhabitants.⁶⁷ After vanquishing the Zunghar regime, Emperor Qianlong (r. 1735–1796) commissioned the *Huangyu Xiyu tuzhi*, intended as a comprehensive survey of Xinjiang to aid the new colonial rule. The project took nearly three decades and involved multiple field

⁶³For an analysis of the divergence between famine-relief manuals and pharmacopeias regarding medicalization, see He Bian, *Know Your Remedies: Pharmacy and Culture in Early Modern China* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2022), 35.

⁶⁴Schottenhammer, “Huihui Medicine,” 85.

⁶⁵For the match in modern Uyghur, see Shang Yanbin, “Huihui douzi,” 173.

⁶⁶Fuheng 傅衡 / 傅衡 (1722–1770) et al., *Qinding Huangyu Xiyu tuzhi*, *Siku quanshu* edition (Taipei: Taiwan shangwu yinshuguan, 1983–86), 43.10a, 10b.

⁶⁷For the Qing’s identification of the Uyghurs in Xinjiang, see David Brophy, *Uyghur Nation: Reform and Revolution on the Russia-China Frontier* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 2016), 32–33.

surveys to complete.⁶⁸ In the case of the *nahu* bean, it is noteworthy that the text cited no alternative names, including the good old “Muslim bean” and the descriptive “eagle’s beak bean,” which circulated for centuries in neighboring regions. *Nahu* likely came from a conversation with local Uyghurs, and its documentation mainly served to register the legume as a newly conquered foreign object.

Returning to the famine-relief manuals, it is clear that the chickpea had become less exotic and yet remained distinctively foreign in a renewed way. The texts present the legume as a modest famine food and make no mention of its foreign provenance, implying that it was widely available. Nevertheless, the authors also identify it with a transliterated name, indicating a growing possibility that Sinophone speakers would learn about the legume from contemporaneous speakers of various Eurasian languages, expanding knowledge from textual sources to oral exchanges. While these encounters may not always be face-to-face, the Sinophone speakers more clearly acknowledged the cultural ownership of the legume by the Turko-Iranian peoples, as evidenced in their efforts to document foreign names phonetically.

It remains a question to me whether the chickpea had truly become widely available to foragers in central and southern China during the Ming and Qing periods. But again, the repeated identification of the legume as an accessible famine food reflects a historical assertion that warrants attention on its own. In the case of the *Jiuhuang bencao*, the author may have aimed to introduce the plant as a food source and to spread word of it, though it was not truly widespread beyond the northwest and his trial ground in Henan. Much like official agronomical treatises, the original text was probably meant to “produce comprehensive, mobile knowledge that could successfully be transferred.”⁶⁹ This hypothesis fits with the transmission history of the *Jiuhuang bencao*, which was largely neglected as a princely undertaking during its first century but came to play an important role in sixteenth-century discussions of famine administration, valued particularly for broadening of the range of food resources.⁷⁰ For the north-based famine specialists, the impetus to promote this plant may have emerged from aspirations to diversify food resources and to create an ambitious infrastructure for famine-relief knowledge across the empire. The result is a redefined identity of the perpetual foreigner in this final episode—a combination of a stronger claim to familiarity and an acknowledgement of a more specific foreignness.

Conclusion

How long does it take for a foreign food to become local? The history of the chickpea suggests that the perception of foreignness does not always align with how long a food has been present. Although both originated in regions west of China, the pea became well integrated into empire-wide daily cuisine and was naturalized in Classical Chinese nomenclature within its first millennium. In contrast, the chickpea maintained a foreign aura, remaining linked to Eurasia and beyond within the same time span.

⁶⁸For the surveys, see Lü Changying 呂長穎, “*Xiyu tuzhi bianzuan yu chengshu yanjiu*” 《西域圖志》編纂與成書研究, (Masters’ thesis, Xinjiang University, 2012), 7–9.

⁶⁹Francesca Bray, *Technology, Gender and History in Imperial China: Great Transformations Reconsidered* (London: Routledge, 2013), 187.

⁷⁰For this history, see Huang, “Mapping the Knowledge,” 111–61.

Taken literally, this perpetual foreignness had to do with the perception of Muslims in the Central Lands. Indeed, the ethno-cultural communities of Muslim faith, whether Persians, Arabs, post-medieval Uyghurs, or Hui, consistently resided in positions secondary to the most dominant ruling power of China. Nevertheless, we should not chalk up the foreignness of the chickpea to a homogenous alterity ascribed to the Muslims. In cultural terms, China during this millennium featured a multi-centered landscape instead of a clear binary of center and peripheries, and “Muslims” encompassed a variety of historical peoples both within and beyond the shifting boundaries of China. During the three periods covered in this paper, the Central Lands were ruled by Mongol, Han, and Manchu elites, each maintaining different relationships with disparate Muslim communities of their times. The Mongols viewed Persians as a key group within the governing class while the Manchus treated the Uyghurs as a colonial subject. Thus, the Muslimness in the Yuan case was exotic yet mainstream, while for the Manchus, it was marginal yet practical. The foreign flavor of the chickpea, therefore, was situational and deeply embedded in changing contexts.

Finally, it is worth noting that the enduring exoticism of the chickpea often carried positive associations, unlike the stigma typically linked to perpetual otherness in humans. The exotic origin of this legume made it stand out on the emperor’s plate, yet it did not prevent it from satisfying the hunger of a humble forager or from integrating into a well-established medical discourse. While the consumption of food can mold identities and chart boundaries, it can also blur and dissolve them.

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